
TRANSPORTATION



Joby Aviation to buy Blade Air Mobility's ride- share business



Kirsten Korosec — 4:18 AM PDT · August 4, 2025

Electric air taxi developer Joby Aviation has agreed to buy Blade Air Mobility's helicopter ride-share business for as much as \$125 million.

Joby is buying the Blade brand and the company's passenger business, which includes operations in the United States and Europe. Blade founder and CEO Rob Wiesenath will continue to lead the business, which will operate as a wholly-owned subsidiary of Joby.

Blade's medical division, which transports organs, isn't included in the transaction and will remain a separate company.

IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY

The deal gives Joby instant access to a network of 12 terminals in key markets like New York City — notably, a dedicated lounge as well as terminal bases at John F. Kennedy International Airport, Newark Liberty Airport, the West Side of Manhattan, the East Side of Manhattan, and Wall Street.

Blade, founded in 2014, doesn't own a fleet of aircraft. Instead, the company has developed a digital network that allows passengers to book private rides on helicopters across several short-hop routes. The service has grown in popularity as well-heeled customers seek out ways to avoid traffic on their commutes from the suburbs into Manhattan, or to The Hamptons for weekends and holidays. The company, which also offers access to

TC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

routes from Nice, France, to Monaco and Saint-Tropez, flew more than 50,000 passengers in 2024.

Joby Aviation founder and CEO Joe Ben Bevirt described the deal as a “strategically important” acquisition that will support its launch of its commercial operations in Dubai and subsequent global rollout. The company said it will integrate its software, which is designed to manage air taxi operations, into Blade’s passenger service.

Joby, founded in 2009 by Bevirt, has been working for more than a decade to develop, certify and produce an electric vertical take off and landing (eVTOL) aircraft for commercial taxi service in cities. (The company is also pursuing a separate [defense-related business](#).) Eventually, the branded Blade service will use electric air taxis, not helicopters in its service, according to the companies.

TC

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Book Your Table >

Most Popular



- The uproar over Vogue’s AI-generated ad isn’t just about fashion
- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Google rolls out Gemini Deep Think AI, a reasoning model that tests multiple ideas in parallel
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren’t even dating apps
- How 2 UC Berkeley dropouts raised \$28M for their AI marketing automation startup
- OpenAI launches Study Mode in ChatGPT

Toyota-backed Joby [went public](#) in 2021 through a merger with Reinvent Technology Partners, a special purpose acquisition company backed by LinkedIn

co-founder Reid Hoffman and Zynga founder Mark Pincus.

Under terms of the agreement, Joby is holding back \$35 million of the purchase price, which will be released if Blade hits certain performance milestones and retains certain key employees.

Topics: [air taxis](#) [blade air mobility](#) [Joby Aviation](#)

[Mergers and Acquisitions](#) [Transportation](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [📧](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Kirsten Korosec

Transportation Editor | [X](#) [f](#) [in](#)

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

Tesla asks shareholders to approve \$29B comp package for Elon Musk amid 'AI talent war'

Sean O'Kane — 4:13 AM PDT · August 4, 2025



Tesla's board of directors has announced a proposed compensation package for CEO Elon Musk that would be worth around \$29 billion in shares, with the company citing the “ever-intensifying AI talent war and Tesla’s position at a critical inflection point” as reasons for the payout.

The new plan will be put to a vote at the company’s annual shareholder meeting, which is scheduled for November. It will also be entirely voided if the Delaware Supreme Court decides to overturn a judge’s [January 2024 decision](#) to strike down Musk’s 2018 compensation package because of how it was negotiated behind the scenes.

Musk has threatened to stop working on AI and

Latest

Security

Startups

AI

Venture

Apps

[Events](#)[Podcasts](#)[Newsletters](#)

At Tesla’s Monday pre-market trading price, that would be worth around \$29 billion. Musk will have to pay a \$23.34-per-share purchase price, bringing the total current value of the award to him to roughly \$26.7 billion. Depending on how the Delaware Supreme Court rules on Tesla’s appeal, the package may be forfeited so “there cannot be any ‘double dip,’ according to Tesla.

“Elon will not be able to keep this new award in addition to the options he will be awarded under the 2018 CEO Performance Award should the courts rule in our favor,” the company wrote.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry’s biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch’s coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).

Tesla said Musk and his brother Kimbal, who is also a board member, recused themselves from the process of constructing this new compensation package. Musk's involvement in the 2018 compensation package, which was worth around \$56 billion, was one of the reasons why Delaware Chancery Court judge chancellor Kathaleen McCormick [decided to strike it down](#) following a trial sparked by a shareholder lawsuit.

McCormick said the process of creating that 2018 plan was "deeply flawed" because of Musk's input and his deep connections to the people on Tesla's board. She also criticized that plan for not including any terms that would bind Musk to Tesla for "any set amount of time" — a likely reason for the two-year pledge included in the new plan.

McCormick's decision caused an uproar among Tesla's largest fans and many of its shareholders. It's also what inspired the company to re-incorporate from Delaware to Texas, a state with fewer established shareholder protections written into its laws. Tesla went as far as holding a shareholder vote to "re-affirm" the pay package. But McCormick [confirmed her decision in December 2024](#), saying the vote and Tesla's legal arguments were "unprecedented theories [that] go against multiple strains of settled law."

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [reddit](#) [envelope](#) [link](#)



Sean O'Kane

Sr. Reporter, Transportation | [X](#)

Sean O’Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology of the...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

jury awards \$200M in damages

Sean O'Kane — 11:24 AM PDT · August 1, 2025



A jury in federal court in Miami has found Tesla partly to blame for a fatal 2019 crash that involved the use of the company's Autopilot driver assistance system.

The jury assessed punitive damages only against Tesla, [CNBC reported](#). The punitive fines coupled with a compensatory damages puts the total payments to around \$242.5 million. The plaintiff's attorney confirmed to TechCrunch that this is the correct amount.

IMAGE CREDITS:

PEERAPON BOONYAKIAT/SOPA

IMAGE/GETTY IMAGES

Neither the driver of the car nor the Autopilot system braked in time to avoid going through an intersection, where the car struck an SUV and killed a pedestrian. The jury assigned the driver two-thirds of the blame, and attributed one-third to Tesla. (The driver was sued separately.)

The verdict comes at the end of a three-week trial over the crash, which killed 20-year-old Naibel Benavides Leon and severely injured her boyfriend Dillon Angulo. The verdict is one of the first major legal decisions about driver assistance technology that has gone against Tesla. The company has previously settled lawsuits [involving similar claims about Autopilot](#).

Latest in Transportation

See More

Brett Schreiber, the lead attorney for the plaintiffs in the case, said in a statement to TechCrunch that Tesla designed Autopilot “only for controlled access highways yet deliberately chose not to restrict drivers from using it elsewhere, alongside Elon Musk telling the world Autopilot drove better than humans.”

“Tesla’s lies turned our roads into test tracks for their fundamentally flawed technology, putting everyday Americans like Naibel Benavides and Dillon Angulo in harm’s way,” said Schreiber. “Today’s verdict represents justice for Naibel’s tragic death and Dillon’s lifelong injuries, holding Tesla and Musk accountable for propping up the company’s trillion-dollar valuation with self-driving hype at the expense of human lives.”

Tesla, in a statement provided to TechCrunch, said it plans to appeal the verdict “given the substantial errors of law and irregularities at trial.”

“Today’s verdict is wrong and only works to set back automotive safety and jeopardize Tesla’s and the entire industry’s efforts to develop and implement life-saving technology,” the company wrote. “To be clear, no car in 2019, and none today, would have prevented this crash. This was never about Autopilot; it was a fiction concocted by plaintiffs’ lawyers blaming the car when the driver — from day one — admitted and accepted responsibility.”

Tesla and Musk spent years making claims about Autopilot’s capabilities that have led to overconfidence in the driver assistance system, a reality that government officials — and Musk himself — have spoken about for years.

The National Transportation Safety Board (NTSB) came to this determination in 2020 after investigating a 2018 crash where the driver died after hitting a concrete barrier. That driver, Walter

TRANSPORTATION



Joby Aviation to buy Blade Air Mobility’s ride-share business

Kirsten Korosec

- 37 minutes ago

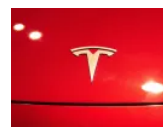
TRANSPORTATION



Tesla asks shareholders to approve \$29B comp package for Elon Musk amid ‘AI talent war’

Sean O’Kane - 41 minutes ago

TRANSPORTATION



Tesla partly liable in Florida Autopilot trial, jury awards \$200M in damages

Sean O’Kane - 3 days ago

Huang, was [playing a mobile game while using Autopilot](#). The NTSB made a number of recommendations following that investigation, which [Tesla largely ignored](#), the [safety board later claimed](#).

On a 2018 conference call, Musk said “complacency” with driver assistance systems like Autopilot is a problem.

“They just get too used to it. That tends to be more of an issue. It’s not a lack of understanding of what Autopilot can do. It’s [drivers] thinking they know more about Autopilot than they do,” Musk [said at the time](#).

The trial took place at a time when Tesla is currently in the [middle of rolling out the first versions of its long-promised Robotaxi network](#), starting in Austin, Texas. Those vehicles are using an enhanced version of Tesla’s more capable driver assistance system, which it calls Full Self-Driving.

Update: This story has been updated to include the amount of compensatory damages in the total.

Topics: [advanced driver assistance systems](#) [Autopilot](#)

[Tesla](#) [Transportation](#)



Sean O'Kane

Sr. Reporter, Transportation | [X](#)

Sean O’Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology of the...

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article

